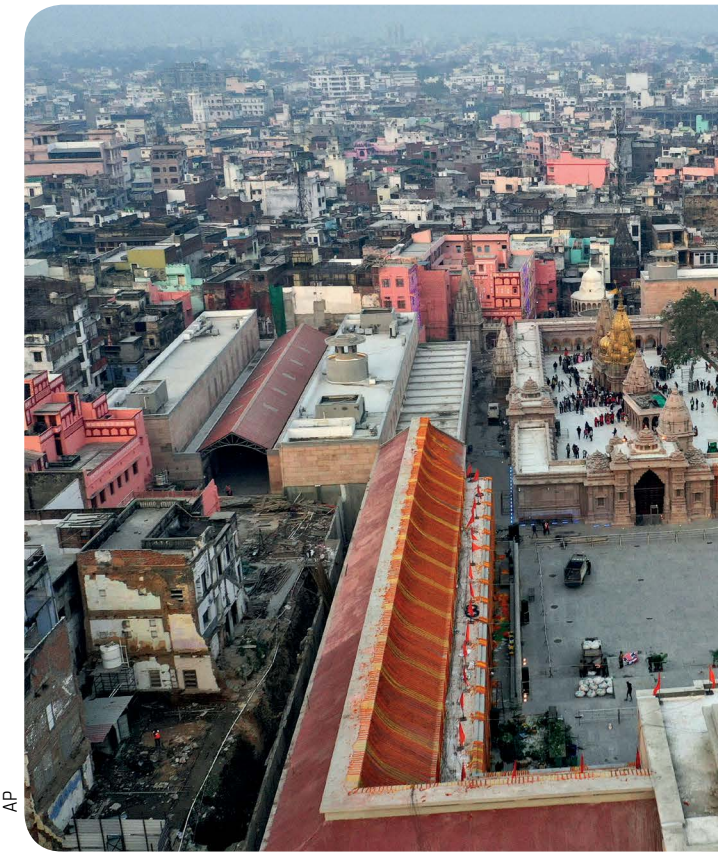
the Muslim organisation involved. But Modi made it clear to the RSS that a solution would be found under the ambit of the Indian Constitution—that is, only after the judicial process was over.

THE BUILD-UP

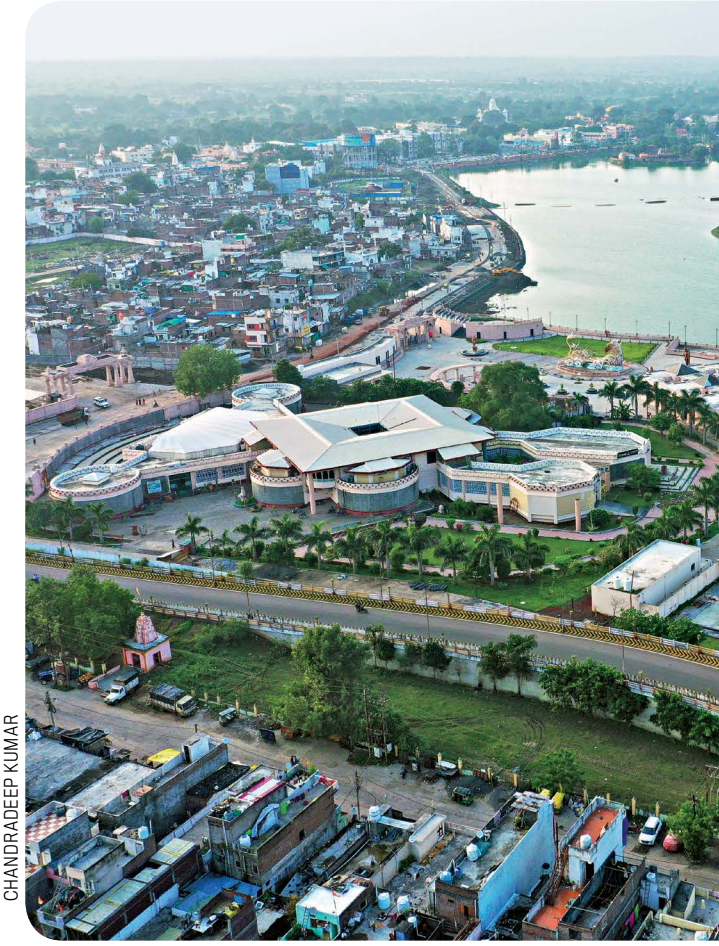
The prime minister's perseverance and patience paid off when, in his second term, the Supreme Court in a landmark judgment on November 9, 2019, concluded that the Babri Masjid was built on top of a "pre-Islamic structure" and acknowledged the Hindu side's claim on the land. The court ordered the disputed 2.77 acres to be handed over entirely to a trust to be created by the government of India to build the Ram Janmabhoomi temple. While condemning the demolition of the Babri Masjid on December 6, 1992 as "an egregious violation of the rule of law", the apex court of the country ruled that the wrong committed must be remedied. It ordered the Uttar Pradesh government to give an alternative five acres of land in Ayodhya to the Muslim organisation to build a mosque to replace the demolished one.

LIKE WITH THE IDOL'S CONSECRATION, MODI WILL REMAIN THE PRIME MOVER, CONDUCTOR AND YAJMAN OF HINDU REVIVAL IN INDIA

Soon after the court's order, the prime minister appointed his former principal secretary, Nripendra Misra, one of his most trusted aides, as chairman of the Ayodhya Ram Mandir Construction Committee, which would coordinate with the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra (SRJBTK) trust that had been formed. A no-nonsense retired IAS officer from the UP cadre, Misra, despite delays and setbacks on account of Covid, ensured that much of the three-storey-high temple—set to have five shikharas—was completed in time for the consecration ceremony. Especially the ground floor where the *garbha griha* or the sanctum sanctorum would be housed. The Opposition accused Modi and the BJP of rushing through with the ceremony even before construction of the temple was complete to garner votes for the general election. But BJP sources say that the date and timing of the consecration ceremony were chosen by the SRJBTK trust based on Vedic astrology, according to which the most



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CHANDRADEEP KUMAR